scheme is not sound and will not result in the creation of an efficient and self-supporting Air Transport system'—came full circle when Civil Aviation Minister Hardeep S. Puri asserted that the government had no choice but to disinvest. By declaring that the 'choice [wasn't] between disinvestment and non-disinvestment' but 'between disinvestment and closing down', with the airline having accumulated a cumulative debt of Rs 60,000 crore, the government echoed JRD's prophetic words.

A few days later, a special audio message from Ratan welcomed the passengers onboard Air India flights. In his now halting but deep voice, he said: '[The] Tata Group … is excited to work together to make Air India the airline of choice in terms of passenger comfort and service.'

Where Air India is concerned, a great deal of work lies ahead. As Michael P. Mascarenhas, chairman of the JRD Tata Memorial Trust and former MD of Air India says, 'When [Ratan] decides to retire, the airline must be left in the hands of solid aviation professionals.' The group has already acted on this. Campbell Wilson, former chief executive officer of Singaporean airline Scoot and a veteran of twenty-six years with 'many important contributions in key management roles', was appointed the MD of Air India in May 2022.

With both the chairman emeritus and chairman, Tata Sons, eager to turn around Air India, there is very little room for a suboptimal outcome. The group had done its homework before acquiring the airline. During the bidding process, Chandrasekaran garnered knowledge from every possible source. He says: 'Whoever wanted to engage [with us], we engaged', and 'we learnt a lot'.

India has the traffic and the cargo opportunity, Chandrasekaran opines. Brimming with confidence, he feels that by 2025, the group will bring about substantial changes in the airline. It is also set to achieve scale by 'bringing all three [Air India, Vistara and AirAsia] under one roof', with one full-service airline and one low-cost carrier. 'We will create a world-class product, best in class customer service, bring the best technology, best safety standards and give that experience to every passenger, not only the first-class passengers,' he says enthusiastically.

Ratan's vision lies behind this goal. Chandrasekaran tells me that after Wilson was appointed, the chairman had requested Ratan for a dinner meeting to introduce the new Air India head. At dinner, Wilson asked Ratan what was the single most important thing he would like to see happen in Air